An Overview of Economic Studies on Gender Bias

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Abstract

Gender issues are becoming increasingly important in the academic field. For instance, Claudia Goldin was awarded the Nobel Prize in Economics "*for having advanced our understanding of women's labour market outcomes*".(Source from official website) Meanwhile, there's growing literature discussing the gender inequality in the family, labor market and its origins. (Altonji and Blank, 1999; Jayachandran, 2015; Bertrand, 2020) This brief overview tries to summarize the studies concerning gender bias that use lab and field experiments in the following five sections.

1 Research Questions

Gender inequality and related stereotypes have long been discussed in sociology and psychology. Papers in these fields mainly focus on the measurement of these concepts and progress or challenges in bridging the gender gap. (Paluck et al., 2021; Breda et al., 2020) However, economists mainly analyze how gender norms affect labor markets, education and intrahousehold dynamics. Thus, they focus on the effect of stereotypes of different people, including teachers' bias, children's bias, employers' bias and females' bias on economic outcomes.

Also, they also test whether changes in economic situations affect the social norms along with the mechanisms inside the impact. This change of economic situations can differ from cash transfer to creation of bank accounts. (Field et al., 2021; Ibrahim, 2023)

Here I mainly focus on papers using lab or field experiments. Therefore, in Section 2, I will describe the experiment design respectively.

2 Experiment Design

2.1 Lab Experiment

For lab experiments, the design can be categorized into two cohorts, control group and evaluation.

For experiments related to control groups, respondents are usually asked to finish tasks like assessing other groups, answering cognitive questions and finishing tasks like a small game (See Nani, 2023 for more details here). Then, different groups will undergo distinctive events. Finally, they will complete a similar task as in the first step. (Bordalo et al., 2016; Coffman, 2014)

While for experiments about evaluation, respondents would answer questions or finish tasks of different types. Then they would be asked to evaluate their behaviors and give estimation on behaviors of people in different cohorts specified before the experiments. (Bordalo et al., 2019; Exley and Kessler, 2022)

2.2 Field Experiment

Next, this review turns to field experiments, which could be separated into experiments about exposure, empowerment and attitude.

Most papers test whether more exposure to female leaders, government officials and professors in a certain field will affect women's future decisions and their related perceptions. (Beaman et al., 2009; Porter and Serra, 2020) They will collect the information before and after some certain shock to show the difference. Also, some papers change the economic empowerment of women and check the female labor market participation rate. (Field et al., 2021) Lastly, some papers directly design some classes or programs advocating the idea of gender equality in a certain region and then see the effect. (Dhar, Jain, and Jayachandran, 2022)

3 Data and Regions

Whether in lab experiments or in field experiments, economists are mostly using questionnaires, Implicit Association Test (See Greenwald, Nosek, and Banaji, 2003), and vignettes to collect people's perceptions of gender issues in a certain scenario.

With respect to regions where the experiments were launched, a large share of papers focus on gender issues in the United States. Meanwhile, since India was known for a lower level of gender equality, a lot of field and lab experiments were also designed there. There are also papers focusing on Italy (Carlana, 2019), China (Du, Xiao, and Zhao, 2021), Peru (Luong, 2023)and Bangladesh (Nani, 2023). Meanwhile, papers also focus on global misperceptions of gender norms. (Bursztyn et al., 2023; Breda et al., 2023)

4 Peer Effect and Human Capital Measure

In general, most papers didn't discuss too much on the measurement of peer effect and human capital. The papers that discuss these topics are mainly doing experiments in the education field. Furthermore, they are testing whether some role models of similar ages or older will affect students' major choices or gender perceptions. And the human capital is usually represented by the test scores or STEM scores. (Carlana, 2019; Dunlap and Barth, 2023)

5 Findings

For issue of gender bias, most findings support that attitudes and stereotypes favoring men do exist in many countries while average gender differences in skills or traits are small compared to differences of within-gender variation. (Jayachandran, 2015; Bertrand, 2020) This supports the conclusion that working women are less likely to receive interest from male suitors. (Afridi et al., 2023) However, some researchers hold that in general male and female applicants are equally likely to be contacted. (Kline, Rose, and Walters, 2022)

A large share of literature seeking to discover whether exposure to more female leaders in many fields will be beneficial reach an agreement that this role model intervention has a significantly positive outcome for women students and workers. Nevertheless, the mechanism behind this differs case by case. (For example, see Porter and Serra, 2020; Beaman et al., 2009; Dasgupta and Asgari, 2004)

Finally, papers put emphasis on the policy effectiveness toward promoting gender equality. Goldin and Rouse (2000) found that the adoption of the screen and blind auditions served to help female musicians in their quest for orchestral positions. While Black and Strahan (2001) showed that policies favoring a more competitive market bridges the wage gap between men and women. And the idea of enabling women to have payments deposited in their bank accounts increases bargaining power inside the family and female labor participation rate. (Field et al., 2021)

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